

Randomised Experiments and Covariates

Ryan T. Moore

American University

2026-07-23

Table of contents I

Preliminaries

How many randomisations are there?

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

Applications: Seguro Popular, Perry Preschool, Ignatieff Campaign

Two Issues: Outliers and Interference

Blocking for Sequential Experiments

Preliminaries

Preliminaries

- ▶ PS1 submitted
- ▶ PS2 submitted
- ▶ Zoom recording links in `/admin/`

Random Assignment Mechanisms

- ▶ Simple/complete randomisation
(Bernoulli trial, prob π)
- ▶ Complete randomisation / random allocation
(fixed proportion to tr)
- ▶ Blocked randomisations
(fixed proportion to tr, w/in group)
- ▶ Cluster randomisations
(assignment at higher level)

Motivation: A Causal Inference Question

“Would a canvassing policy increase enrolment in a health insurance programme?”

Motivation: A Causal Inference Question

“Would a canvassing policy increase enrolment in a health insurance programme?”

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol %
1	Dem		
2	Dem		
3	Rep		
4	Rep		

Motivation: A Causal Inference Question

Suppose we observationally measure

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol %
1	Dem	Yes	60
2	Dem	Yes	70
3	Rep	No	20
4	Rep	No	30
Diff in Means: (Yes — No)			40

Motivation: A Causal Inference Question

Suppose we observationally measure

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol %
1	Dem	Yes	60
2	Dem	Yes	70
3	Rep	No	20
4	Rep	No	30
Diff in Means: (Yes - No)			40

Causal claims? Concerns?

Motivation: A Causal Inference Question

Suppose we randomly assign 2 Tr, 2 Co, and measure

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enroll %
1	Dem	Yes	60
2	Dem	Yes	70
3	Rep	No	20
4	Rep	No	30
Diff in Means: (Yes - No)			40

Motivation: A Causal Inference Question

Suppose we randomly assign 2 Tr, 2 Co, and measure

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enroll %
1	Dem	Yes	60
2	Dem	Yes	70
3	Rep	No	20
4	Rep	No	30
Diff in Means: (Yes – No)			40

Causal claims? Concerns?

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

► $\rightsquigarrow$ sample imbalance

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!

Seriously?

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!

Seriously? Well, ...

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!

Seriously? Well, ...

```
x <- sample(0:1, size = 10, replace = TRUE)
```

```
x
```

```
## [1] 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1 1
```

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!
- ▶ CLT SE for diff in means:

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!
- ▶ CLT SE for diff in means:

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!
- ▶ CLT SE for diff in means:

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Var}(Y_i(0)) = \text{Var}(Y_i(1))$, allocate units equally.

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!
- ▶ CLT SE for diff in means:

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Var}(Y_i(0)) = \text{Var}(Y_i(1))$, allocate units equally. Say 5 treated, 4 control. What to do with 10th village?

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!
- ▶ CLT SE for diff in means:

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Var}(Y_i(0)) = \text{Var}(Y_i(1))$, allocate units equally. Say 5 treated, 4 control. What to do with 10th village?
 - ▶ $10^{th} \rightarrow$ control: $SE : \sqrt{\frac{5}{5} + \frac{5}{5}} = \sqrt{2}$

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!
- ▶ CLT SE for diff in means:

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Var}(Y_i(0)) = \text{Var}(Y_i(1))$, allocate units equally. Say 5 treated, 4 control. What to do with 10th village?
 - ▶ $10^{th} \rightarrow$ control: $SE : \sqrt{\frac{5}{5} + \frac{5}{5}} = \sqrt{2}$
 - ▶ $10^{th} \rightarrow$ treated: $SE : \sqrt{\frac{6}{4} + \frac{4}{6}} = \sqrt{2.66}$

We knew: do better than draw

$$T_i \sim \text{Bern}(\pi)$$

- ▶ $\leadsto$ sample imbalance
- ▶ Might get no treateds!
- ▶ CLT SE for diff in means:

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Var}(Y_i(0)) = \text{Var}(Y_i(1))$, allocate units equally. Say 5 treated, 4 control. What to do with 10th village?
 - ▶ $10^{th} \rightarrow$ control: $SE : \sqrt{\frac{5}{5} + \frac{5}{5}} = \sqrt{2}$
 - ▶ $10^{th} \rightarrow$ treated: $SE : \sqrt{\frac{6}{4} + \frac{4}{6}} = \sqrt{2.66}$
- ▶ If $\text{Var}(Y_i(0)) \neq \text{Var}(Y_i(1))$, allocate $\rightarrow$ higher-Variance condition

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) > 0$, larger SE, less precision
- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) < 0$, smaller SE, *more* precision

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) > 0$, larger SE, less precision
- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) < 0$, smaller SE, *more* precision

Demonstration:

Unit	Y_0	Y_1 (+ cov)	Y_1 (− cov)
1	0	0	10
2	5	5	5
3	10	10	0
Means	5	5	5

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) > 0$, larger SE, less precision
- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) < 0$, smaller SE, *more* precision

Demonstration:

Unit	Y_0	Y_1 (+ cov)	Y_1 (− cov)
1	0	0	10
2	5	5	5
3	10	10	0
Means	5	5	5

Suppose assign 1 to Tr, 2 to Co.

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) > 0$, larger SE, less precision
- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) < 0$, smaller SE, *more* precision

Demonstration:

Unit	Y_0	Y_1 (+ cov)	Y_1 (− cov)
1	0	0	10
2	5	5	5
3	10	10	0
Means	5	5	5

Suppose assign 1 to Tr, 2 to Co.

$$\widehat{ATE}_{+cov} = -7.5, 0, 7.5$$

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) > 0$, larger SE, less precision
- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) < 0$, smaller SE, *more* precision

Demonstration:

Unit	Y_0	Y_1 (+ cov)	Y_1 (− cov)
1	0	0	10
2	5	5	5
3	10	10	0
Means	5	5	5

Suppose assign 1 to Tr, 2 to Co.

$$\widehat{ATE}_{+cov} = -7.5, 0, 7.5$$

$$\widehat{ATE}_{-cov} = 2.5, 0, -2.5$$

$$SE(\widehat{ATE}) = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \left[\frac{m \text{Var}(Y_i(0))}{N-m} + \frac{(N-m) \text{Var}(Y_i(1))}{m} + 2 \text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) \right]}$$

- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) > 0$, larger SE, less precision
- ▶ If $\text{Cov}(Y_i(0), Y_i(1)) < 0$, smaller SE, *more* precision

Demonstration:

Unit	Y_0	Y_1 (+ cov)	Y_1 (− cov)
1	0	0	10
2	5	5	5
3	10	10	0
Means	5	5	5

Suppose assign 1 to Tr, 2 to Co.

$$\widehat{ATE}_{+cov} = -7.5, 0, 7.5$$

$$\widehat{ATE}_{-cov} = 2.5, 0, -2.5 \text{ (less variance!)}$$

Summary

To minimise (parametric) variance/SE:

Summary

To minimise (parametric) variance/SE:

- ▶ If equal variances, make $n_{Tr} = n_{Co}$
- ▶ If unequal variances, more units to higher variance condition (to a point)
- ▶ If possible, define outcome s.t.
 $Cov(Y(1), Y(0)) < 0$

Summary

To minimise (parametric) variance/SE:

- ▶ If equal variances, make $n_{Tr} = n_{Co}$
- ▶ If unequal variances, more units to higher variance condition (to a point)
- ▶ If possible, define outcome s.t.
 $Cov(Y(1), Y(0)) < 0$
- ▶ Contrasting treatments: individs respond opposite directions
- ▶ Email *A* makes Dems donate a lot, Reps none
- ▶ Email *B* makes Reps donate a lot, Dems none

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

But, is obs difference causal?

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

But, is obs difference causal?

What do we really want to know?

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

But, is obs difference causal?

What do we really want to know?

Does canvassing actually *change* enrolment in precinct?
(Or, just Party $\rightarrow$ Enrolment?)

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

But, is obs difference causal?

What do we really want to know?

Does canvassing actually *change* enrolment in precinct?
(Or, just Party $\rightarrow$ Enrolment?)

What *would have* happened to “No” precincts if “Yes”?

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

But, is obs difference causal?

What do we really want to know?

Does canvassing actually *change* enrolment in precinct?
(Or, just Party $\rightarrow$ Enrolment?)

What *would have* happened to “No” precincts if “Yes”?

What would have happened under *other* conditions?

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Suppose we can know both *potential outcomes* ...

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	—	20	60
2	Dem	—	30	70
3	Rep	—	20	30
4	Rep	—	30	40
Means:			25	50

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Suppose we can know both *potential outcomes* ...

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	—	20	60
2	Dem	—	30	70
3	Rep	—	20	30
4	Rep	—	30	40
Means:			25	50

$$\text{ATE} = 50 - 25 = 25$$

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Suppose we can know both *potential outcomes* ...

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	—	20	60
2	Dem	—	30	70
3	Rep	—	20	30
4	Rep	—	30	40
Means:			25	50

$$\text{ATE} = 50 - 25 = 25$$

(True or an estimate?)

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Another way to think about same information:

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass	True Precinct Effect
1	Dem	—	20	60	40
2	Dem	—	30	70	40
3	Rep	—	20	30	10
4	Rep	—	30	40	10
Means:			25	50	25

$$\text{ATE} = (40 + 40 + 10 + 10)/4 = 25$$

The Fundamental Problem of Causal Inference

We can't observe both “Canvassed” and “Not Canvassed” for a precinct.

We can't observe both *potential outcomes* (*counterfactuals*).

So, how can we get a good causal estimate?

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Suppose we observe ...

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	Yes		60
2	Dem	Yes		70
3	Rep	No	20	
4	Rep	No	30	
Means:			25	65

$$\text{Estimated ATE} = 65 - 25 = 40$$

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Suppose we observe ...

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	Yes		60
2	Dem	Yes		70
3	Rep	No	20	
4	Rep	No	30	
Means:			25	65

Estimated ATE = $65 - 25 = 40$ ☹ (too big)

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Or, we could have observed ...

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Or, we could have observed ...

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	Yes		60
2	Dem	No	30	
3	Rep	Yes		30
4	Rep	No	30	
Means:			30	45

Estimated ATE = $45 - 30 = 15$

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Or, we could have observed ...

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	Yes		60
2	Dem	No	30	
3	Rep	Yes		30
4	Rep	No	30	
Means:			30	45

Estimated ATE = $45 - 30 = 15$ ☹ (too small; closer)

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

In our random allocation, possible data were

Assignments	Est ATE
YYNN	40

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

In our random allocation, possible data were

Assignments	Est ATE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNNY	15
NNYY	10

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

In our random allocation, possible data were

Assignments	Est ATE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

► Some closer to truth

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

In our random allocation, possible data were

Assignments	Est ATE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

► Some closer to truth

►
$$E(\hat{\tau}) = \frac{1}{6} \cdot 40 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 35 + \frac{1}{3} \cdot 25 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 15 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 10 = 25 = \bar{\tau}$$

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

In our random allocation, possible data were

Assignments	Est ATE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

► Some closer to truth

►
$$E(\hat{\tau}) = \frac{1}{6} \cdot 40 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 35 + \frac{1}{3} \cdot 25 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 15 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 10 = 25 = \bar{\tau}$$

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

In our random allocation, possible data were

Assignments	Est ATE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

► Some closer to truth

► $E(\hat{\tau}) = \frac{1}{6} \cdot 40 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 35 + \frac{1}{3} \cdot 25 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 15 + \frac{1}{6} \cdot 10 = 25 = \bar{\tau}$
(unbiased)

A Problem

In practice, we don't know all potential outcomes.

A Problem

In practice, we don't know all potential outcomes.

Two assignments (YYNN and NNYN) leave treatment perfectly confounded with party.

A Problem

In practice, we don't know all potential outcomes.

Two assignments (YYNN and NNYN) leave treatment perfectly confounded with party.

We can never see all of Y_1 , Y_0 . But we can see all of X !

A Problem

In practice, we don't know all potential outcomes.

Two assignments (YYNN and NNNY) leave treatment perfectly confounded with party.

We can never see all of Y_1 , Y_0 . But we can see all of X !

Let's ensure X does not predict T .

A Solution

Blocking:

Creating pre-treatment groups that look same on *predictors*.

A Solution

Blocking:

Creating pre-treatment groups that look same on *predictors*.

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem			
2	Dem			
3	Rep			
4	Rep			

A Solution

Blocking:

Creating pre-treatment groups that look same on *predictors*.

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem			
2	Dem			
3	Rep			
4	Rep			

(Then, random allocate **within** groups.)

A Solution

Blocking:

Creating pre-treatment groups that look same on *predictors*.

Precinct	Party	Canvass?	Enrol % if No Canvass	Enrol % if Canvass
1	Dem	Y		60
2	Dem	N	30	
3	Rep	N	20	
4	Rep	Y		40

(Then, random allocate **within** groups.)

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Blocking restricts possible data to

Assignments	Est TE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Blocking restricts possible data to

Assignments	Est TE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

Estimates have **less variance**, are **closer to true ATE**.

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Blocking restricts possible data to

Assignments	Est TE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

Estimates have **less variance**, are **closer to true ATE**.

Under random allocation, 5 possible estimates: 40, 15, 25, 35, 10.

Blocking **restricts** to 3 best: 15, 25, 35.

Example: Canvassing and Enrolment

Blocking restricts possible data to

Assignments	Est TE
YYNN	40
NYNY	35
YNNY	25
NYYN	25
YNYN	15
NNYY	10

Estimates have **less variance**, are **closer to true ATE**.

Under random allocation, 5 possible estimates: 40, 15, 25, 35, 10.

Blocking **restricts** to 3 best: 15, 25, 35.



How many randomisations are there?

How many randomisations are there?

Suppose $n = 4$ units

► Bernoulli randomisation: $2^n = 2^4 = 16$

How many randomisations are there?

Suppose $n = 4$ units

- ▶ Bernoulli randomisation: $2^n = 2^4 = 16$
- ▶ Random allocation: ${}_nC_{n/2} = {}_4C_2 = \frac{4!}{2!(4-2)!} = 6$

How many randomisations are there?

Suppose $n = 4$ units

- ▶ Bernoulli randomisation: $2^n = 2^4 = 16$
- ▶ Random allocation: ${}_nC_{n/2} = {}_4C_2 = \frac{4!}{2!(4-2)!} = 6$
- ▶ Blocked pairs randomisation: $2^{\frac{n}{2}} = 2^{\frac{4}{2}} = 4$

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

- ▶ Randomisation *should* balance potential outcomes $\leadsto (Y(1), Y(0)) \perp\!\!\!\perp T$, by design

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

- ▶ Randomisation *should* balance potential outcomes $\leadsto (Y(1), Y(0)) \perp\!\!\!\perp T$, by design
- ▶ But, can't check directly. False in example: $T \rightarrow Y(1)$

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

- ▶ Randomisation *should* balance potential outcomes
 $\leadsto (Y(1), Y(0)) \perp\!\!\!\perp T$, by design
- ▶ But, can't check directly. False in example: $T \rightarrow Y(1)$
- ▶ (And, works better w/ bigger samples, fewer subgroups of interest)

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

- ▶ Randomisation *should* balance potential outcomes
 $\leadsto (Y(1), Y(0)) \perp\!\!\!\perp T$, by design
- ▶ But, can't check directly. False in example: $T \rightarrow Y(1)$
- ▶ (And, works better w/ bigger samples, fewer subgroups of interest)
- ▶ Can't observe all potential outcomes

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

- ▶ Randomisation *should* balance potential outcomes $\rightsquigarrow (Y(1), Y(0)) \perp\!\!\!\perp T$, by design
- ▶ But, can't check directly. False in example: $T \rightarrow Y(1)$
- ▶ (And, works better w/ bigger samples, fewer subgroups of interest)
- ▶ Can't observe all potential outcomes
- ▶ **Can** observe X 's, predictors of Y

Blocking: Randomisation Improved

- ▶ Randomisation *should* balance potential outcomes $\rightsquigarrow (Y(1), Y(0)) \perp\!\!\!\perp T$, by design
- ▶ But, can't check directly. False in example: $T \rightarrow Y(1)$
- ▶ (And, works better w/ bigger samples, fewer subgroups of interest)
- ▶ Can't observe all potential outcomes
- ▶ **Can** observe X 's, predictors of Y
- ▶ Check whether $T \overset{?}{\Rightarrow} X$

Why Block?

- ▶ Covariate **balance**

Why Block?

- ▶ Covariate **balance**
- ▶ Estimate **closer to truth**

Why Block?

- ▶ Covariate **balance**
- ▶ Estimate **closer to truth**
- ▶ Increased **efficiency**

Why Block?

- ▶ Covariate **balance**
- ▶ Estimate **closer to truth**
- ▶ Increased **efficiency**
- ▶ Triply-robust estimates: block, randomise, adjust

Why Block?

- ▶ Covariate **balance**
- ▶ Estimate **closer to truth**
- ▶ Increased **efficiency**
- ▶ Triply-robust estimates: block, randomise, adjust
- ▶ Block-level effects
 - ↪ different actors interested in different effects

Why Block?

- ▶ Covariate **balance**
- ▶ Estimate **closer to truth**
- ▶ Increased **efficiency**
- ▶ Triply-robust estimates: block, randomise, adjust
- ▶ Block-level effects
 - ↪ different actors interested in different effects
- ▶ Guidelines for limited/uncertain resources

Why Block?

Imai, King, and Stuart (2008):

Define *population average treatment effect*, PATE:

$$\text{PATE} \equiv \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N TE_i$$

Why Block?

Imai, King, and Stuart (2008):

Define *population average treatment effect*, PATE:

$$\text{PATE} \equiv \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N TE_i$$

and observed difference in sample means, D :

$$D \equiv \frac{1}{n/2} \sum_{i \in \{I_i=1, T_i=1\}} Y_i - \frac{1}{n/2} \sum_{i \in \{I_i=1, T_i=0\}} Y_i$$

Why Block?

Imai, King, and Stuart (2008):

Define *population average treatment effect*, PATE:

$$\text{PATE} \equiv \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N TE_i$$

and observed difference in sample means, D :

$$D \equiv \frac{1}{n/2} \sum_{i \in \{I_i=1, T_i=1\}} Y_i - \frac{1}{n/2} \sum_{i \in \{I_i=1, T_i=0\}} Y_i$$

then, the total *estimation error* is

$$\Delta \equiv \text{PATE} - D$$

Why Block?

The *estimation error* can be decomposed:

$$\Delta = \underbrace{\Delta_S}_{\text{sampling error}} + \underbrace{\Delta_T}_{\text{treatment imbalance}}$$

Why Block?

The *estimation error* can be decomposed:

$$\Delta = \underbrace{\Delta_S}_{\text{sampling error}} + \underbrace{\Delta_T}_{\text{treatment imbalance}}$$

Further,

$$\Delta = \underbrace{\Delta_{S_X}}_{\text{sampling error from obs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{S_U}}_{\text{sampling error from unobs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{T_X}}_{\text{treatment imbalance from obs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{T_U}}_{\text{treatment imbalance from unobs}}$$

Why Block?

The *estimation error* can be decomposed:

$$\Delta = \underbrace{\Delta_S}_{\text{sampling error}} + \underbrace{\Delta_T}_{\text{treatment imbalance}}$$

Further,

$$\Delta = \underbrace{\Delta_{S_X}}_{\text{sampling error from obs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{S_U}}_{\text{sampling error from unobs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{T_X}}_{\text{treatment imbalance from obs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{T_U}}_{\text{treatment imbalance from unobs}}$$

Blocking controls Δ_{T_X}

Why Block?

The *estimation error* can be decomposed:

$$\Delta = \underbrace{\Delta_S}_{\text{sampling error}} + \underbrace{\Delta_T}_{\text{treatment imbalance}}$$

Further,

$$\Delta = \underbrace{\Delta_{S_X}}_{\text{sampling error from obs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{S_U}}_{\text{sampling error from unobs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{T_X}}_{\text{treatment imbalance from obs}} + \underbrace{\Delta_{T_U}}_{\text{treatment imbalance from unobs}}$$

Blocking controls Δ_{T_X} , and, to the degree correlated, Δ_{T_U} .

Usual Blocking

- ▶ Exact on one or two discrete covariates
(best predictor)

Usual Blocking

- ▶ Exact on one or two discrete covariates
(best predictor)
- ▶ More covariates: no exact comparable units
(5 covars, 3 levels: $3^5 = 243$)

Usual Blocking

- ▶ Exact on one or two discrete covariates
(best predictor)
- ▶ More covariates: no exact comparable units
(5 covars, 3 levels: $3^5 = 243$)
- ▶ More covariates often done informally

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

Moore (2012)

- ▶ Like matching on PS, MD, start with dimension reduction

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

Moore (2012)

- ▶ Like matching on PS, MD, start with dimension reduction
- ▶ Like matching, select an algorithm

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

Moore (2012)

- ▶ Like matching on PS, MD, start with dimension reduction
- ▶ Like matching, select an algorithm
- ▶ Like matching, select other attributes (caliper, etc.)

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

- ▶ Collect the predictors $\mathbf{X}$

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

- ▶ Collect the predictors $\mathbf{X}$
- ▶ Calculate how different units are from each other on $\mathbf{X}$'s

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

- ▶ Collect the predictors $\mathbf{X}$
- ▶ Calculate how different units are from each other on $\mathbf{X}$'s
 - ▶ Mahalanobis distance between every pair of units:

$$MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \hat{\Sigma}^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$$

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

- ▶ Collect the predictors $\mathbf{X}$
- ▶ Calculate how different units are from each other on $\mathbf{X}$'s

- ▶ Mahalanobis distance between every pair of units:

$$MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \hat{\Sigma}^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$$

- ▶ Create blocks of similar units

Multivariate, Continuous Blocking

- ▶ Collect the predictors $\mathbf{X}$
- ▶ Calculate how different units are from each other on $\mathbf{X}$'s

- ▶ Mahalanobis distance between every pair of units:

$$MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \hat{\Sigma}^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$$

- ▶ Create blocks of similar units
- ▶ Randomise within blocks

A Matrix of Distances

(First 5 rows of `x100`, variables `b1` and `b2`)

	1001	1002	1003	1004	1005
1001	0.00	2.68	2.51	2.46	1.36
1002	2.68	0.00	2.80	1.77	1.71
1003	2.51	2.80	0.00	1.09	1.53
1004	2.46	1.77	1.09	0.00	1.11
1005	1.36	1.71	1.53	1.11	0.00

Classes of Blocking Algorithms

- ▶ Optimal: consider all blockings; pick best.
(High-order problem)

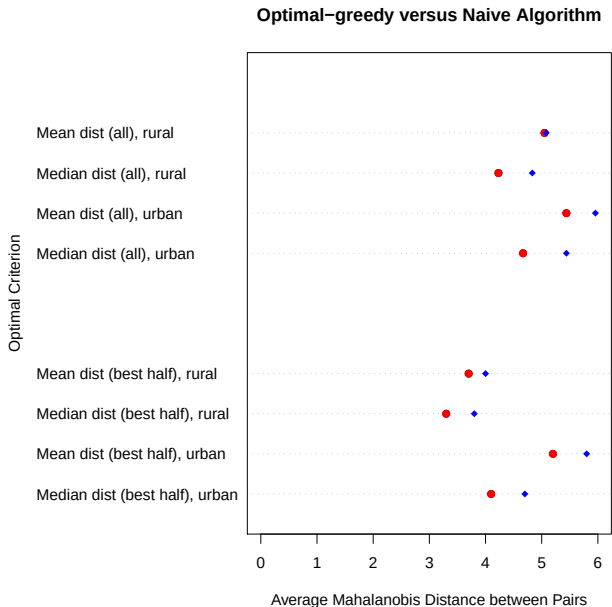
Classes of Blocking Algorithms

- ▶ Optimal: consider all blockings; pick best.
(High-order problem)
- ▶ Optimal-greedy: consider all distances, pick best.

Classes of Blocking Algorithms

- ▶ Optimal: consider all blockings; pick best.
(High-order problem)
- ▶ Optimal-greedy: consider all distances, pick best.
- ▶ Naïve greedy: Get best block for this unit now.

Which Multivariate Blocking Algorithm? (optimal greedy)



Deploying Limited Resources: opt-greedy algorithm

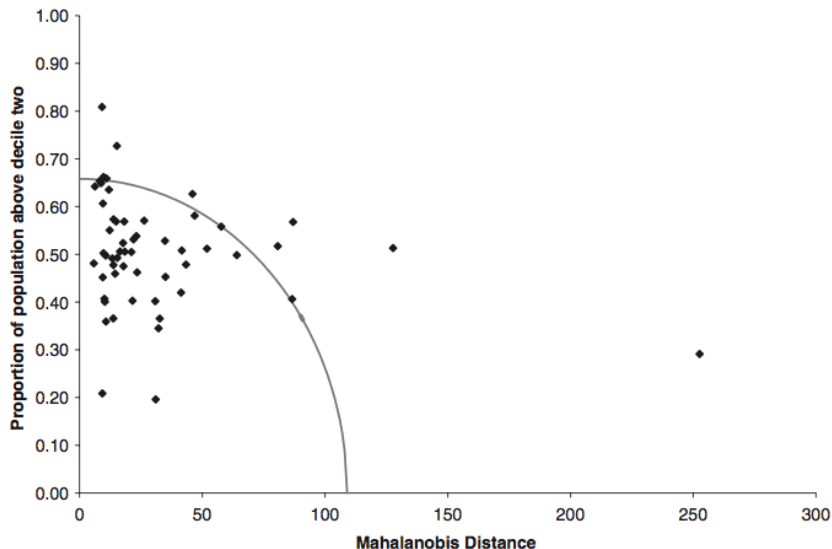


Figure 4. Choosing a subset of pairs for survey. We conducted our survey in 100 of

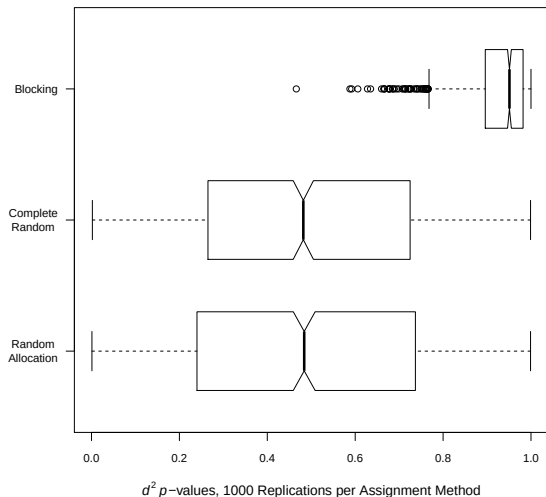
Why Block: Balance

Why Block: Balance

Simulation study: 100 units, $X_1 \sim N(0, 1)$, $X_2 \sim \text{Unif}(0, 1)$, $X_3 \sim \chi^2_2$; 1000 such experiments. Assg treatment in 3 ways.
 p -value from `xBalance`.

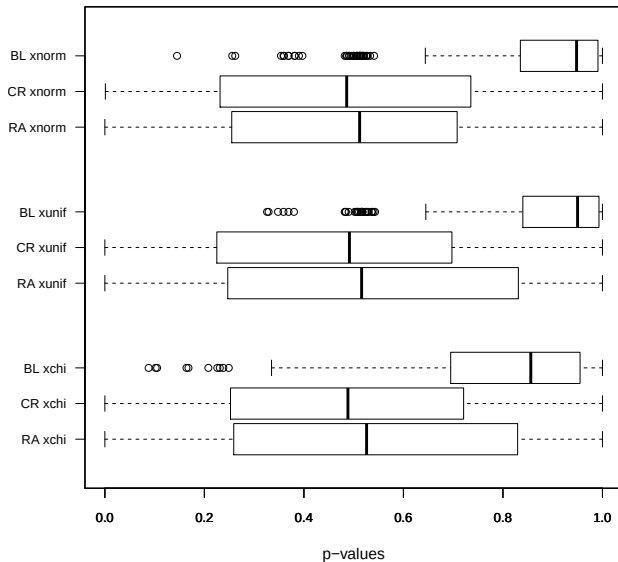
Why Block: Balance

Simulation study: 100 units, $X_1 \sim N(0, 1)$, $X_2 \sim \text{Unif}(0, 1)$, $X_3 \sim \chi^2_2$; 1000 such experiments. Assg treatment in 3 ways. p -value from `xBalance`.

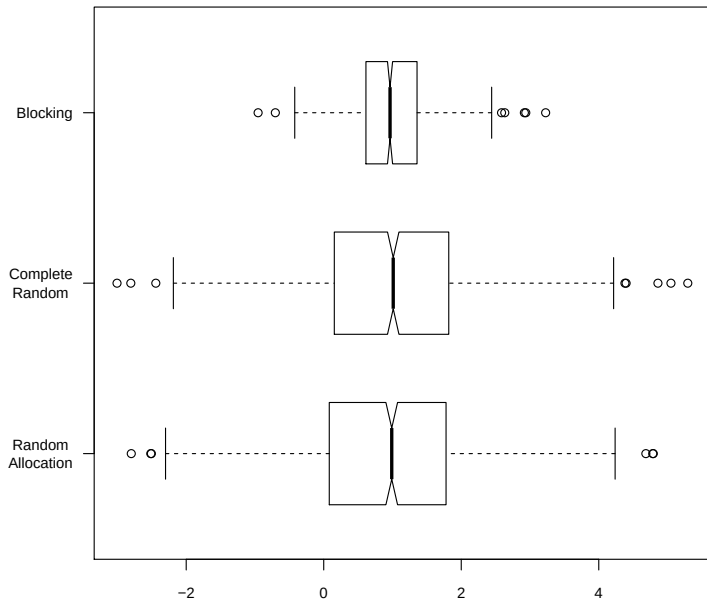


Why Block: Balance

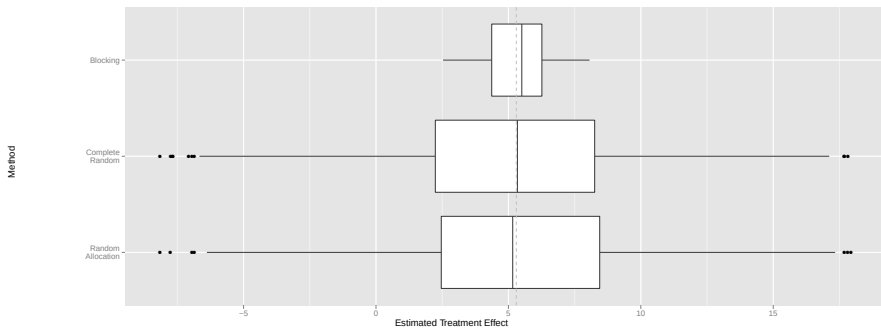
Kolmogorov-Smirnov Tests



Why Block: Efficiency



Why Block: Efficiency under TE Heterogeneity



Applications: Seguro Popular, Perry
Preschool, Ignatieff Campaign

Experiment: Randomised Health Infrastructure & Insurance

King et al. (2009)

- ▶ **Intervention:** resources for medical services, preventive care, pharmaceuticals, access, and financial health protection
- ▶ **Beneficiaries:** 50M Mexicans (half the pop) w/o access to health care
- ▶ **Cost** 2005 full +1% GDP new money annually
- ▶ One of **largest** health reforms of any country in 2 decades
- ▶ Most **visible** accomplishment of Fox administration
- ▶ Major **issue** 2006 pres. campaign (vote choice effect: 7-11% for PAN)
- ▶ **Randomised** 74/148 health clusters to first roll-out, infrastructure spending, encouragement to enroll
- ▶ But – do **better** than pure coin flip

Designing the *Seguro Popular* Experiment

How can we learn **most** from 148 cluster experiment?

- ▶ Ensure causes of HH expenditures evenly *balanced* betwn Tr and Co
(otherwise, Tr might be poorer, or Co more insured)
- ▶ Make sure effect estimates as *precise* as possible
(prefer estimate of “9 to 11%” to “−10 to 30%”)

Designing the *Seguro Popular* Experiment

► Data on clusters:

cluster	population	educ years	doctors	nurses
MCSSA000364	3130	4.00	1	1
MCSSA000504	6492	5.11	1	1
MCSSA008221	5096	4.26	2	2

Designing the *Seguro Popular* Experiment

- Data on clusters:

cluster	population	educ years	doctors	nurses
MCSSA000364	3130	4.00	1	1
MCSSA000504	6492	5.11	1	1
MCSSA008221	5096	4.26	2	2

- Calculate how different clusters are from each other

Designing the *Seguro Popular* Experiment

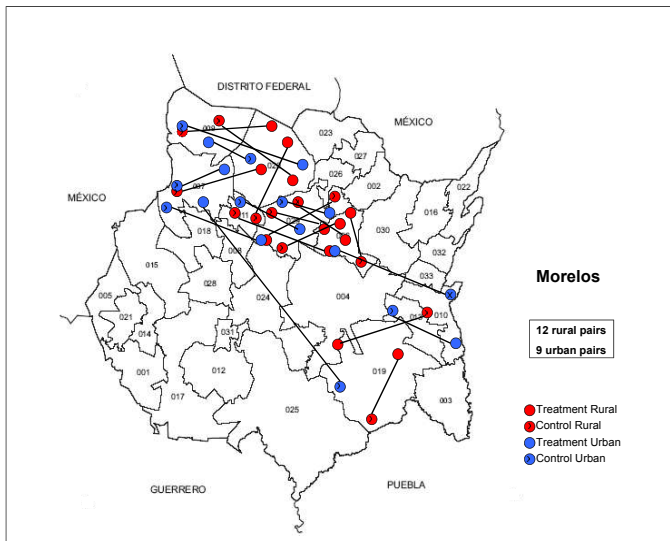
- Data on clusters:

cluster	population	educ years	doctors	nurses
MCSSA000364	3130	4.00	1	1
MCSSA000504	6492	5.11	1	1
MCSSA008221	5096	4.26	2	2

- Calculate how different clusters are from each other
- Mahalanobis distance between every pair of units:

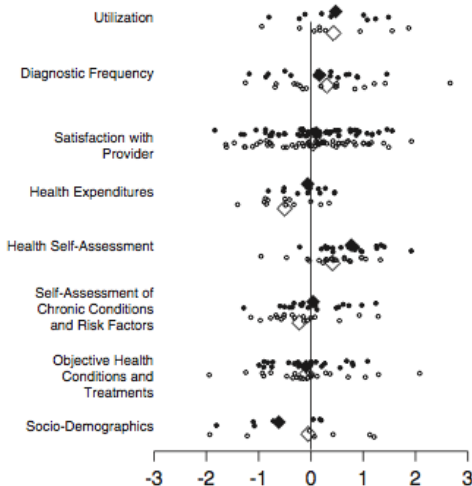
$$MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \hat{\Sigma}^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$$

Blocked Pairs, Morelos



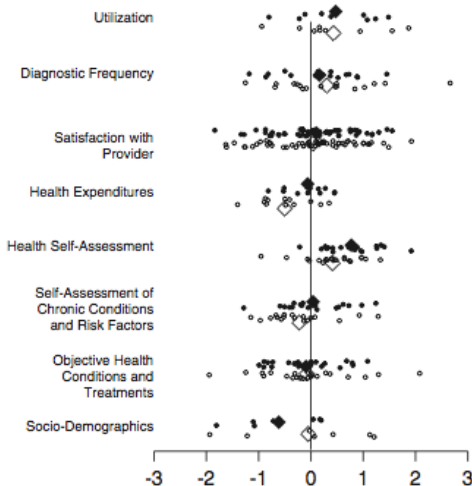
Balance in Baseline Outcomes, *Seguro Popular*

King et al. (2007)



Balance in Baseline Outcomes, *Seguro Popular*

King et al. (2007)



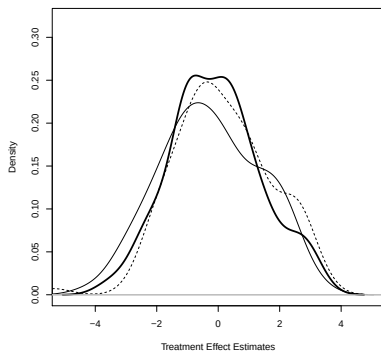
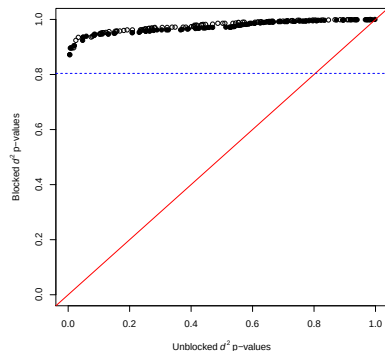
(Plus, SE's would have been $2\times$ to $6\times$ larger!)

Blocking in Applications: Balance and Efficiency

Moore (2012): Perry Preschool Experiment

Left: QQ plot of balance (100 blocked vs. unblocked)

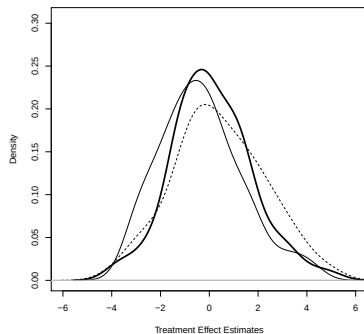
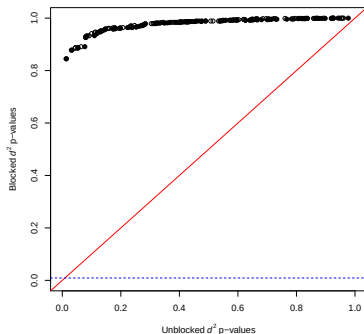
Right: Est TE under sharp null (100 blocked vs. unblocked)



(SES, gender, IQ)

Balance in Applications: Balance and Efficiency

Considering more variables ...



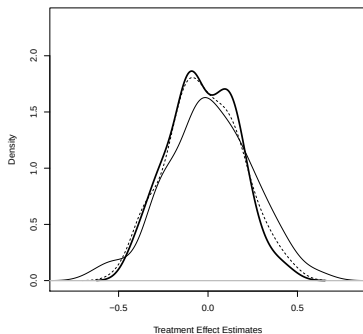
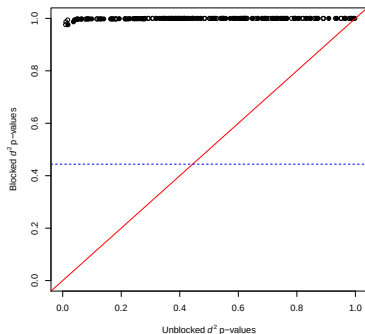
(+ siblings, AFDC, mom empl, educ, father, ...)

Balance in Applications

Loewen and Rubenson (2011): persuade party delegates to support Ignatieff

Left: QQ plot of balance (100 blocked vs. unblocked)

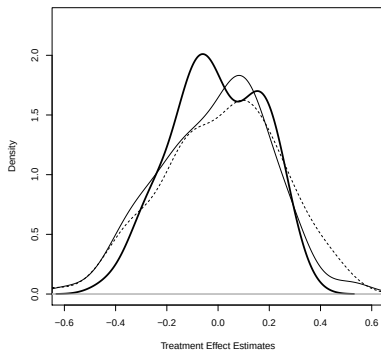
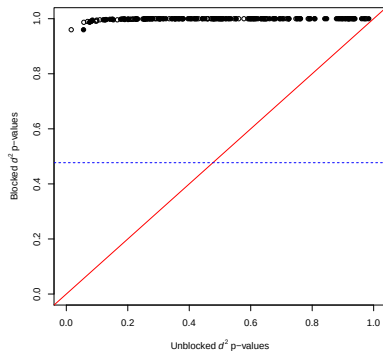
Right: Est TE under sharp null (100 blocked vs. unblocked)



(province, pledged, special constituency)

Balance in Applications

Considering more variables ...



(+ attention, interest)

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Moore and Schnakenberg (2025)

In R,

```
library(blockTools)
data(x100)
head(x100)
```

	id	id2	b1	b2	g	ig
1	1001	101	156	795	b	729
2	1002	102	813	469	a	627
3	1003	103	950	978	a	959
4	1004	104	991	781	a	661
5	1005	105	613	759	a	819
6	1006	106	654	838	b	643

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Block:

```
block.out <- block(data = x100, id.vars = "id",  
                  block.vars = c("b1", "b2"))
```

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Block:

```
block.out <- block(data = x100, id.vars = "id",  
                  block.vars = c("b1", "b2"))
```

	Unit 1	Unit 2	Distance
1	1043	1040	0.01240000
2	1100	1020	0.02259275
3	1065	1027	0.02912651
4	1085	1081	0.03498815
5	1088	1061	0.04789253

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Assign:

```
assg.out <- assignment(block.out, seed = 157)
```

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Assign:

```
assg.out <- assignment(block.out, seed = 157)
```

	Treatment 1	Treatment 2	Distance
1	1043	1040	0.01240000
2	1020	1100	0.02259275
3	1027	1065	0.02912651
4	1085	1081	0.03498815
5	1061	1088	0.04789253

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Diagnose:

```
diagnose(assg.out, data = x100, id.vars = "id",  
         suspect.var = "b1", suspect.range = c(0,5))
```

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Diagnose:

```
diagnose(assg.out, data = x100, id.vars = "id",  
         suspect.var = "b1", suspect.range = c(0,5))
```

Get block IDs

```
createBlockIDs(assg.out, data = x100, id.var = "id")
```

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Diagnose:

```
diagnose(assg.out, data = x100, id.vars = "id",  
         suspect.var = "b1", suspect.range = c(0,5))
```

Get block IDs

```
createBlockIDs(assg.out, data = x100, id.var = "id")
```

Get balance:

```
assg2xBalance(assg.out, x100, id.var = "id",  
              bal.vars = c("b1", "b2"))
```

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Extract conditions:

```
extract_conditions(assign.out, x100, id.var = "id")
```

```
[1] 2 1 1 2 2 2 2 2 1 2 2 1 1 2 1 2 2 2 2 1 2 1 1 1 2 1 1  
[38] 1 1 2 2 1 1 1 2 2 2 1 2 2 2 1 2 1 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 1 1  
[75] 1 2 1 2 2 2 2 1 1 1 1 2 1 2 2 2 1 1 1 2 1 1 1 2 1 2
```

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with blockTools

Extract conditions:

```
extract_conditions(assg.out, x100, id.var = "id")
```

```
[1] 2 1 1 2 2 2 2 2 1 2 2 1 1 2 1 2 2 2 2 1 2 1 1 1 2 1 1  
[38] 1 1 2 2 1 1 1 2 2 2 1 2 2 2 1 2 1 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 1 1  
[75] 1 2 1 2 2 2 2 1 1 1 1 2 1 2 2 2 1 1 1 2 1 1 1 2 1 2
```

```
x100 |> mutate(condition = extract_conditions(assg.out, x100))
```

	id	id2	b1	b2	g	ig	condition
1	1001	101	156	795	b	729	2
2	1002	102	813	469	a	627	1
3	1003	103	950	978	a	959	1
4	1004	104	991	781	a	661	2
5	1005	105	613	759	a	819	2
6	1006	106	654	838	b	643	2
7	1007	107	640	645	c	12	2
8	1008	108	681	404	a	221	2

Two Issues: Outliers and Interference

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

$$\blacktriangleright MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$$

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

- ▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$
- ▶ How to estimate Σ ?

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

- ▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$
- ▶ How to estimate Σ ?
 - ▶ resistant covariance

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

- ▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$
- ▶ How to estimate Σ ?
 - ▶ resistant covariance
 - ▶ regular covariance

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

- ▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$
- ▶ How to estimate Σ ?
 - ▶ resistant covariance
 - ▶ regular covariance
 - ▶ manual weighting

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

- ▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$
- ▶ How to estimate Σ ?
 - ▶ resistant covariance
 - ▶ regular covariance
 - ▶ manual weighting
 - ▶ identity matrix (Euclidean dist)

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

- ▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$
- ▶ How to estimate Σ ?
 - ▶ resistant covariance
 - ▶ regular covariance
 - ▶ manual weighting
 - ▶ identity matrix (Euclidean dist)
- ▶ Resistant covariance estimators

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

- ▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$
- ▶ How to estimate Σ ?
 - ▶ resistant covariance
 - ▶ regular covariance
 - ▶ manual weighting
 - ▶ identity matrix (Euclidean dist)
- ▶ Resistant covariance estimators
 - ▶ MCD (Minimum Covariance Determinant)
1 constraint: include h points in interior

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

▶ $MD_{ij} = \sqrt{(\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)' \Sigma^{-1} (\mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j)}$

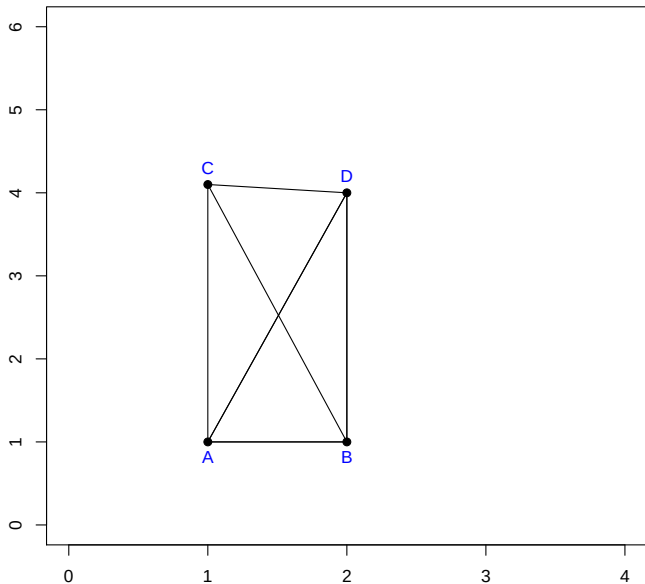
▶ How to estimate Σ ?

- ▶ resistant covariance
- ▶ regular covariance
- ▶ manual weighting
- ▶ identity matrix (Euclidean dist)

▶ Resistant covariance estimators

- ▶ MCD (Minimum Covariance Determinant)
1 constraint: include h points in interior
- ▶ MVE (Minimum Volume Ellipsoid)
2 constraints: include h points, $p + 1$ points on boundary

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling



Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

Given outliers, use resistant estimates of Σ and blocks will stay *same*:

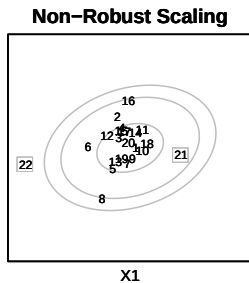
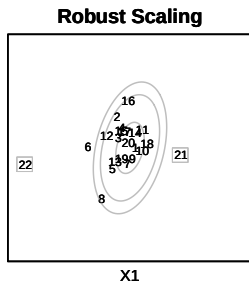
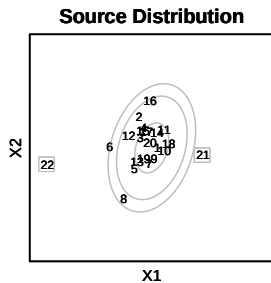
Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling

Given outliers, use resistant estimates of Σ and blocks will stay *same*:

Scale Matx	Points	Distance from A		
		B	C	D
Cov	$A-D$	1.73	1.76	2.45
Cov	$A-D + (1, 100)$	2.00	0.08	2.03
Cov	$A-D + (20, 100)$	1.72	1.01	0.74
MCD	$A-D$	1.73	1.76	2.45
MCD	$A-D + (1, 100)$	1.73	1.76	2.45
MCD	$A-D + (20, 100)$	1.73	1.76	2.45
MVE	$A-D$	1.73	1.76	2.45
MVE	$A-D + (1, 100)$	1.73	1.76	2.45
MVE	$A-D + (20, 100)$	1.73	1.76	2.45

(**Bold** = closest to A)

Covariate Weightings: Resistant Scaling



Covariate Weightings

Baseline: Exclude outliers, regular MD

	Unit 1	Unit 2	Distance
1	15	4	0.18
2	9	7	0.37
3	13	5	0.37
4	18	10	0.43
5	17	3	0.44
6	14	11	0.50
7	20	1	0.65
8	16	2	0.95
9	12	6	1.32
10	19	8	2.12

Covariate Weightings

Include outliers, resistant MD: Same blocks! ☺

	Unit 1	Unit 2	Distance
1	15	4	0.18
2	13	5	0.37
3	9	7	0.42
4	18	10	0.46
5	17	3	0.50
6	14	11	0.59
7	20	1	0.76
8	16	2	1.03
9	12	6	1.56
10	19	8	2.18
11	22	21	13.43

Covariate Weightings

Include outliers, non-resistant MD: **Blocks shuffled by outliers** ☹

	Unit 1	Unit 2	Distance
1	17	15	0.12
2	9	7	0.24
3	19	13	0.25
4	14	11	0.28
5	10	1	0.33
6	12	3	0.45
7	4	2	0.58
8	20	18	0.69
9	8	5	1.45
10	22	6	2.24
11	21	16	3.64

Interference

- ▶ We worry that effects may spillover:
interference
- ▶ But nearby units are similar!
- ▶ Restrict blocks to units in a range

Multivariate Continuous Blocking with `blockTools`

Other arguments to `block()`

- ▶ `vcov.data`
- ▶ `n.tr`
- ▶ `algorithm`
- ▶ `distance`: `mahalanobis`, `mcd`, `mve`
- ▶ `weight`
- ▶ `level.two`: block states by most similar cities
- ▶ `valid.var`, `valid.range`: Goldilocks
- ▶ `seed`: (for `mcd` and `mve`)

Blocking for Sequential Experiments

What about Sequential Experiments?

Moore and Moore (2013)



What about Sequential Experiments?

Moore and Moore (2013)

tall, male,
senior, biology



What about Sequential Experiments?

Moore and Moore (2013)

Have info!



Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

Biased coins

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

Biased coins

Define unique covariate profile $\mathbf{p}$

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

Biased coins

Define unique covariate profile $\mathbf{p}$

use

$$Pr(t = T) = \begin{cases} \frac{2}{3} & \text{if } n_{\mathbf{p}T} < n_{\mathbf{p}C} \\ \frac{1}{3} & \text{if } n_{\mathbf{p}T} > n_{\mathbf{p}C} \end{cases}$$

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

Minimisation

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

Minimisation

Given $\mathbf{p}$, score each variable s_j , $\left(\frac{n_{\mathbf{p}C} - n_{\mathbf{p}T}}{n_{\mathbf{p}C} + n_{\mathbf{p}T} + 1} \right)$
combine (sum), rank conditions, assign π 's

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

Minimisation

Given $\mathbf{p}$, score each variable s_j , $\left(\frac{n_{\mathbf{p}C} - n_{\mathbf{p}T}}{n_{\mathbf{p}C} + n_{\mathbf{p}T} + 1}\right)$
combine (sum), rank conditions, assign π 's

	Gender		Age	
	M	F	Young	Old
Control	1	3	3	3
Treatment	2	4	3	1
s_j (Old M)	$-\frac{1}{4}$			$\frac{2}{5}$

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

Minimisation

Given $\mathbf{p}$, score each variable s_j , $\left(\frac{n_{\mathbf{p}C}-n_{\mathbf{p}T}}{n_{\mathbf{p}C}+n_{\mathbf{p}T}+1}\right)$
combine (sum), rank conditions, assign π 's

	Gender		Age	
	M	F	Young	Old
Control	1	3	3	3
Treatment	2	4	3	1
s_j (Old M)	$-\frac{1}{4}$			$\frac{2}{5}$

(bias toward Treatment)

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

1. Biased coins

$\leadsto$ require unique, replicated covariate profiles

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

1. Biased coins

~> require unique, replicated covariate profiles

2. Minimization

~> ignores joint distribution

Perfect balance?	Gender		Age	
	M	F	Young	Old
Control	3	3	3	3
Treatment	3	3	3	3

Common Discrete Covariate-Adaptive Allocations

1. Biased coins

~> require unique, replicated covariate profiles

2. Minimization

~> ignores joint distribution

Perfect balance?	Gender		Age	
	M	F	Young	Old
Control	3	3	3	3
Treatment	3	3	3	3

Perfect imbalance?				
	Young M	Old M	Young F	Old F
Control	3	0	0	3
Treatment	0	3	3	0

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance

$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)
- ▶ Test on variety of data

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)
- ▶ Test on variety of data
 - ▶ Uncorrelated MVN

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)
- ▶ Test on variety of data
 - ▶ Uncorrelated MVN
 - ▶ **Correlated MVN**

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)
- ▶ Test on variety of data
 - ▶ Uncorrelated MVN
 - ▶ **Correlated MVN**
 - ▶ Correlated MVN with outliers

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile **p**
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)
- ▶ Test on variety of data
 - ▶ Uncorrelated MVN
 - ▶ **Correlated MVN**
 - ▶ Correlated MVN with outliers
 - ▶ Bimodal (extreme correlated MVN)

My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile $\mathbf{p}$
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
)
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)
- ▶ Test on variety of data
 - ▶ Uncorrelated MVN
 - ▶ **Correlated MVN**
 - ▶ Correlated MVN with outliers
 - ▶ Bimodal (extreme correlated MVN)
 - ▶ **Realistic data**

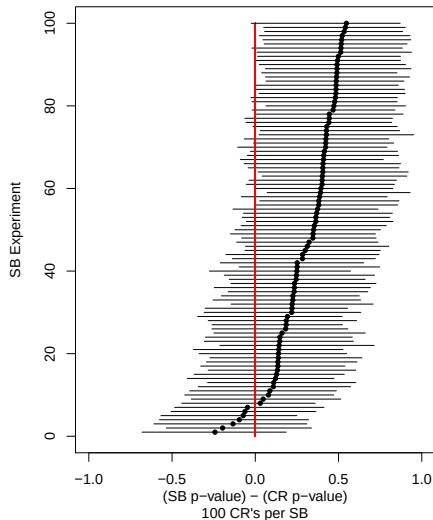
My Approach

- ▶ Allow discrete covariates, restriction to exact profile **p**
- ▶ Move beyond counts in conditions
- ▶ Incorporate ordered, continuous covariates
 - ▶ Define dissimilarity between current unit and conditions
(Average pairwise Mahalanobis distance)
$$\overline{MD}_{qt} = \frac{1}{R} \sum_{r=1}^R MD_{qr}$$
 - ▶ Assign higher prob to more dissimilar conditions (k -times, proportional to MD)
- ▶ Test on variety of data
 - ▶ Uncorrelated MVN
 - ▶ **Correlated MVN**
 - ▶ Correlated MVN with outliers
 - ▶ Bimodal (extreme correlated MVN)
 - ▶ **Realistic data**
- ▶ Implement in actual sequential trial

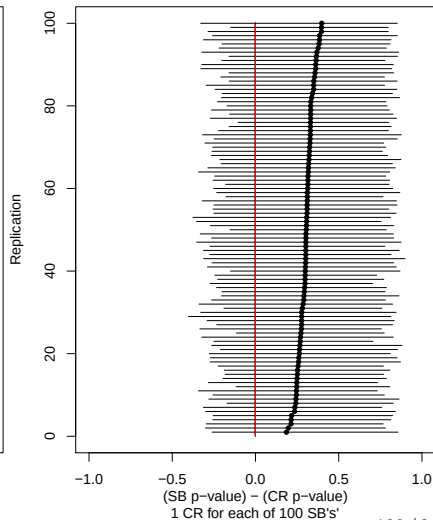
Seq. Blocking More Balanced than CR

Correlated MVN

SB More Balanced than CR

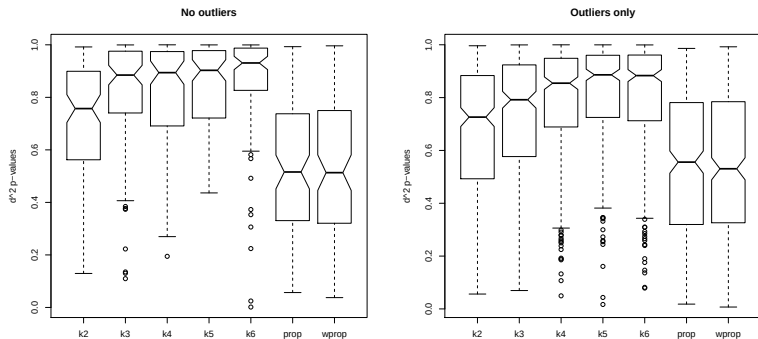


SB More Balanced than CR



Selecting a Method for Experiments

Simulate (48 units, realistic means, SDs, bivariate corrs for 10 covariates) $\times 100$



Sequential PTSD Experiment Background

- ▶ Background: PTSD impairs retrieval of specific autobiographical memories
- ▶ Question: Does practice lead to short-term changes in PTSD symptoms?

Sequential PTSD Experiment Background

- ▶ Background: PTSD impairs retrieval of specific autobiographical memories
- ▶ Question: Does practice lead to short-term changes in PTSD symptoms?
- ▶ Recruitment
 - ▶ Inclusion: veterans with PTSD diagnosis, 18-64

Sequential PTSD Experiment Background

- ▶ Background: PTSD impairs retrieval of specific autobiographical memories
- ▶ Question: Does practice lead to short-term changes in PTSD symptoms?
- ▶ Recruitment
 - ▶ Inclusion: veterans with PTSD diagnosis, 18-64
 - ▶ Exclusion: psychotic disorder, bipolar disorder, substance abuse in last month, substance dependence in last year, recent psychiatric hospitalization, current suicidal intent

Sequential PTSD Experiment Background

- ▶ Background: PTSD impairs retrieval of specific autobiographical memories
- ▶ Question: Does practice lead to short-term changes in PTSD symptoms?
- ▶ Recruitment
 - ▶ Inclusion: veterans with PTSD diagnosis, 18-64
 - ▶ Exclusion: psychotic disorder, bipolar disorder, substance abuse in last month, substance dependence in last year, recent psychiatric hospitalization, current suicidal intent
- ▶ 52 assigned total; 46 assigned Nov 09 - Jan 11; 39 follow-up.

Sequential PTSD Experiment Background

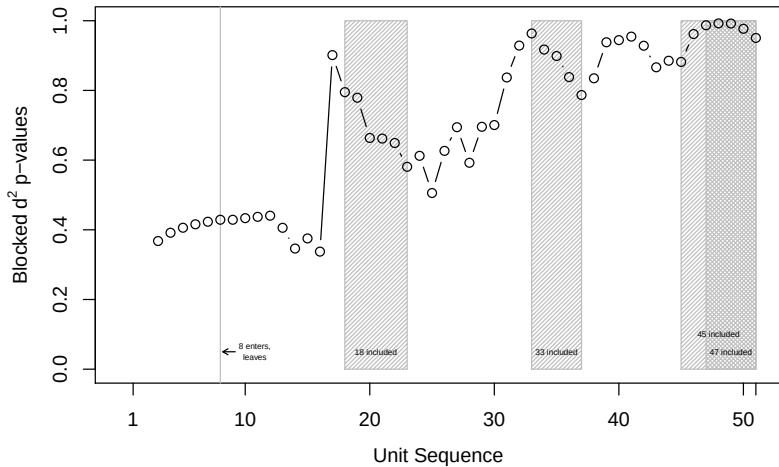
- ▶ Background: PTSD impairs retrieval of specific autobiographical memories
- ▶ Question: Does practice lead to short-term changes in PTSD symptoms?
- ▶ Recruitment
 - ▶ Inclusion: veterans with PTSD diagnosis, 18-64
 - ▶ Exclusion: psychotic disorder, bipolar disorder, substance abuse in last month, substance dependence in last year, recent psychiatric hospitalization, current suicidal intent
- ▶ 52 assigned total; 46 assigned Nov 09 - Jan 11; 39 follow-up.
- ▶ Two Conditions (daily practice)
 - ▶ **memory**: retrieve specific memories of life events in response to cue words
 - ▶ **anagrams**: rearrange letters of cue words to create new words (control)

Inputting Data in Real Time: Generalized Query

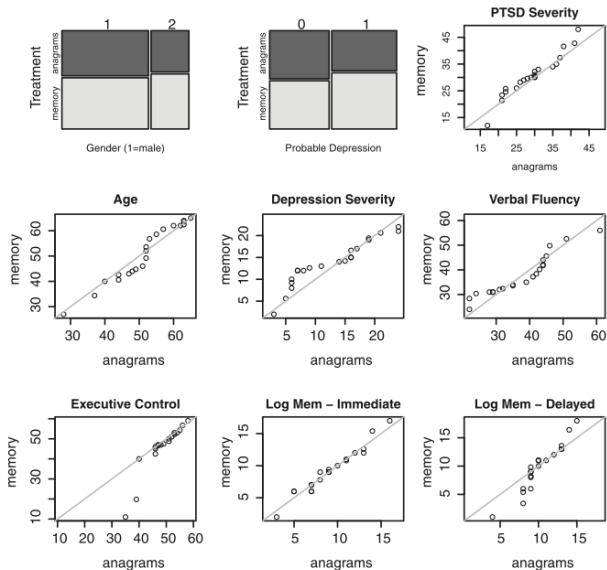
Unit 1

```
> seqblock1(query=T)
How many identification variables are there?
> 1
Enter the name of ID variable 1 without quotation marks.
> id
Enter the value of 'id'.
> 10624
How many exact blocking variables are there?
> 0
How many blocking variables are there?
> 2
Enter the name of blocking variable 1.
> x1
Enter the value of `x1`.
> 100
Should `x1` be restricted to certain values? [n/y]
> no
Enter the name of blocking variable 2.
> x2
Enter the value of `x2`.
> 80
How many experimental/treatment conditions are there?
> 2
```

Balance: Moore & Moore 2013



Balance: Moore & Moore 2013



RI Confidence Intervals from `blockTools`

Get RI confidence interval from sequentially blocked data:

```
set.seed(407357912)
df <- tibble(id = 1:50,
             prov = sample(1:2, 50, replace = TRUE),
             age = sample(seq(18, 55, 1), 50, replace = TRUE),
             treat = sample(0:1, 50, replace = TRUE),
             yobs = treat + sample(15:20, 50, replace = TRUE))
```

RI Confidence Intervals from blockTools

Get RI confidence interval from sequentially blocked data:

```
set.seed(407357912)
df <- tibble(id = 1:50,
             prov = sample(1:2, 50, replace = TRUE),
             age = sample(seq(18, 55, 1), 50, replace = TRUE),
             treat = sample(0:1, 50, replace = TRUE),
             yobs = treat + sample(15:20, 50, replace = TRUE))
```

Check summary statistics:

```
df |> group_by(treat) |> summarise(m_yobs = mean(yobs))
```

```
# A tibble: 2 x 2
```

	treat	m_yobs
	<int>	<dbl>
1	0	17.7
2	1	18.3

RI Confidence Intervals from blockTools

Get RI confidence interval from sequentially blocked data:

```
invertRIconfInt(df,  
  outcome.var = "yobs", tr.var = "treat",  
  tau.abs.min = -2, tau.abs.max = 3,  
  tau.length = 20, n.sb.p = 200,  
  id.vars = "id", id.vals = "id",  
  exact.vars = c("prov", "age"), exact.vals =
```

RI Confidence Intervals from blockTools

Get RI confidence interval from sequentially blocked data:

```
invertRIconfInt(df,  
  outcome.var = "yobs", tr.var = "treat",  
  tau.abs.min = -2, tau.abs.max = 3,  
  tau.length = 20, n.sb.p = 200,  
  id.vars = "id", id.vals = "id",  
  exact.vars = c("prov", "age"), exact.vals =
```

```
$ci95
```

```
[1] -0.16  0.11  0.37  0.63  0.89  1.16  1.42
```

```
$ci90
```

```
[1] -0.16  0.11  0.37  0.63  0.89  1.16
```

```
$ci80
```

```
[1] 0.11  0.37  0.63  0.89  1.16
```

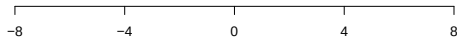
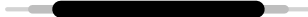
RI Confidence Intervals: Moore & Moore 2013

Blocked estimates 9-15% more efficient

Rand Inf
conf ints



t-test
conf ints



(Adjusted) Outcome Estimate

Analysis for Blocked Designs

If assignment probability for i varies by block j , let $p_{ij} = m_{ij}/N_j$. Weight each obs with

$$w_{ij} = \frac{d_i}{p_{ij}} + \frac{1 - d_i}{1 - p_{ij}}$$

Testing for Blocked Designs

‘As ye randomise so shall ye analyse’

Testing for Blocked Designs

‘As ye randomise so shall ye analyse’

If blocks used to randomise, incorporate into RI.

Testing for Blocked Designs

‘As ye randomise so shall ye analyse’

If blocks used to randomise, incorporate into RI.

1. Use actual blocks created, when possible
2. Reassign hypothetical treatment 1000 times
3. Obtain distribution of ATEs under (e.g.) sharp null
4. Compare observed ATE to randomisation distribution

Next:
Clustered Designs, Regression and
Experiments
PS3 due Monday

References I

- Imai, Kosuke, Gary King, and Elizabeth A. Stuart. 2008. "Misunderstandings Between Experimentalists and Observationalists about Causal Inference." *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society, Series A* 171 (2): 481–502.
- King, Gary, Emmanuela Gakidou, Kosuke Imai, Jason Lakin, Ryan T. Moore, Clayton Nall, Nirmala Ravishankar, et al. 2009. "Public Policy for the Poor? A Randomized Assessment of the Mexican Universal Health Insurance Program." *The Lancet* 373 (9673): 1447–54.
- King, Gary, Emmanuela Gakidou, Nirmala Ravishankar, Ryan T. Moore, Jason Lakin, Manett Vargas, Martha María Téllez-Rojo, Juan Eugenio Hernández Ávila, Mauricio Hernández Ávila, and Héctor Hernández Llamas. 2007. "A 'Politically Robust' Experimental Design for Public Policy Evaluation, with Application to the Mexican Universal Health Insurance Program." *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management* 26 (3): 479–509.

References II

- Loewen, Peter John, and Daniel Rubenson. 2011. “For Want of a Nail: Negative Persuasion in a Party Leadership Race.” *Party Politics* 17 (1): 45–65.
- Moore, Ryan T. 2012. “Multivariate Continuous Blocking to Improve Political Science Experiments.” *Political Analysis* 20 (4): 460–79. <https://doi.org/10.1093/pan/mps025>.
- Moore, Ryan T., and Sally A. Moore. 2013. “Blocking for Sequential Political Experiments.” *Political Analysis* 21 (4): 507–23.
- Moore, Ryan T., and Keith Schnakenberg. 2025. *blockTools: Blocking, Assignment, and Diagnosing Interference in Randomized Experiments*. <https://doi.org/10.32614/CRAN.package.blockTools>.